line with the PM's thinking, the GoI decided to take a different approach. Dr P.K. Mishra chaired a meeting with secretaries of various ministries and thought too that if this was going to snowball into a global pandemic, all of the government would need to be actively involved. He was going to have to deal with this problem as soon as possible.

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The Ministry of External Affairs was in close contact with the US Secretary of State and the Indian ambassador to the US. Both countries were tracking the development of the spread of the disease very closely. President Donald Trump was scheduled to visit India in the third week of February, but naturally that would change based on the status of the spread of the pathogen in both countries.

As the month of February progressed, the virus spread most prominently in Italy, Asia and the Middle East. Global markets began to take big hits. President Trump did not cancel his state visit. In fact, his meetings with Prime Minister Modi helped reinforce relationship between the two largest democracies of the world. They established an understanding that although there was some friction on both sides regarding the new trade deal, it wouldn't spill over on strategic areas of convergence such as defence and security cooperation.[19] Since India was still pretty much insulated from the virus, a grand event—'Namaste Trump'—was organized in Ahmedabad, with an audience of over 1,10,000 people. The president and the first lady were given a red-carpet welcome at the ceremonial state reception at the Rashtrapati Bhavan. It was only when Trump boarded Air Force One to return was he informed that a senior director of the US's Centers for Disease Control and Prevention had during a media briefing earlier in the day indicated the possibility of closing down schools, remote working and using internet-based teleschooling, if the COVID-19 cases kept going up. She had warned that the situation was 'rapidly evolving and expanding' and that 'it's not so much a question of *if* this will happen anymore but rather more a question of exactly *when* this will happen and how many people in the country will have severe illness'.[20]

When he was in India, both India and the US hardly had any COVID-19 cases and hence the state visit and the gatherings looked par for the course. However, a few months later, in May 2020, Gujarat Congress claimed that